‘humiliation’, in his words, of often having to borrow money to make ends meet. On one occasion, he was so hard up that he ended up selling his cufflinks. But he was quite happy cleaning planes and pushing and moving them around from one hangar to another and to designated places for extra cash.

Ratan flew solo in just eight hours, compared to the fifteen to twenty hours that most trainees normally take. On that memorable day when he first flew alone, he recalls the instructor saying, ‘Take her around’, ‘and so, I still remember the empty stick with nobody there [at the instructor’s seat],’ Ratan says. ‘Suddenly you could see the instruments and you are saying no-no, I am not ready as yet, and he said yes you are and walks out so that flight is yours, and after landing you feel tall, so it was a great experience.’ He passed his written test in his first attempt as well and took to the skies. He was only in the first year of his architecture course when he got his private flying licence. It was a dream come true for the twenty-year-old.

From then on, he missed no opportunity to fly and made a habit to do so virtually every weekend, alone or with friends. His preferred season for flying was summer and he occasionally skipped classes for it. Then he would work into the night to catch up with his studies. He also invited his classmates ‘to come up and savour the enjoyment or excitement of flying’. His favourite aircraft was the four-seater Piper Tri-Pacer. To the ordinary eye, the fabric-covered tubular construction of the aircraft might seem hardly airworthy and outright scary. Though it could not attain great speed, it boasted of a robust performance, which enabled Ratan to pull some aerobatic stunts. Revealing his penchant to play pranks, he says: ‘At times I used to try and scare [my classmates].’ Bob Fox, Ratan’s junior at Cornell, recalls that Ratan did the ‘stalls’, switching off the engine after the plane gained some scary height and letting it almost nosedive. The location of the Pacer’s engine in the front made the angle of the drop sharper. After Ratan did a stall with him during a flight, Fox remarks that it was ‘one of the scarier moments of my life’.

One of Ratan’s Cornell colleagues, Nick Scott, recalled a double date he had gone on with Ratan. They met the ladies at the meadows that were once the Cortland Municipal Airport, nearly twenty-four miles from Ithaca.

For the date, Ratan arrived in style, flying an aircraft. He swooped over the horizon and landed on the strip. In classic style, he taxied close to where the awestruck girls stood. Bringing the aircraft to a halt, both boys, ‘in